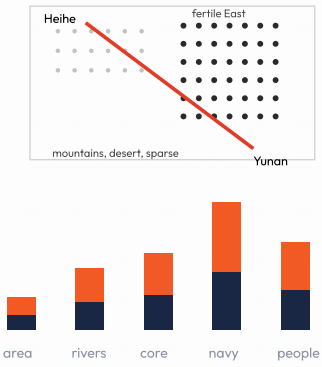
INFOGRAPHIC · TIM MARSHALL, PRISONERS OF GEOGRAPHY

CHINA'S DEVELOPMENT AND WHY AFRICA'S PATH IS DIFFERENT

DATA 1

Agriculture + geographical features

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, an imaginary line from Heihe to the province of Yunan, explains the disparity of China's population and how China developed in the way it did: the fertile east is densely populated and the West is not. Terrain, climate and fertile soil shaped the developed, leading it to...



DATA 2

Borders + buffer zones

China's large geographical expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones in the border regions to protect it from instability and possible threats. The buffers act as a deterrent to invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors to aid development. This is a by-...



buffer ring · neighbours kept out

DATA 3

Naval exploits + sea navigation

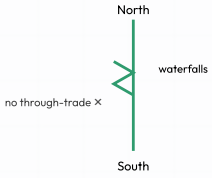
A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders, now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea, displaying naval dominance over a local area. This allows China to divide countries, control trade and trade routes, access an expanse of natural resources, commence fishing on a large scale and open employment in different sectors of the economy.

1. Similarities
2. Differences
3. Which would be bigger?
4. Why does one develop faster?

DATA 4

Natural barriers

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Its great rivers are broken by waterfalls and rapids, so they are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. It has little connectiveness to European and even Asian countries, as well as the fact that the north and south are poorly connected- they basically operate as two separate polarised states. Trade and infrastructure are...



DATA 5

Population growth

Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African. The continent as a whole, to accommodate this massive increase in numbers will need to not only increase agricultural gain to feed everyone, but heavily develop infrastructure for example housing and...



1 in 4
will be African



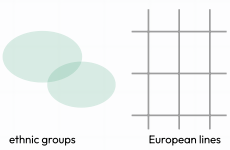
1 in 4
will be African

DATA 6

Borders drawn by colonialism + war

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups, for example in Sudan and Somalia. This promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and economic instability. It contrasts with China's centralised, unified core protected by buffer zones and limits the possibilities of agreement and local trade within the continent.





SIMILARITIES
Both are large-scale regions, whose development was

DIFFERENCES
China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains

WHICH WOULD BE BIGGER?
Africa is roughly three times China's land area, acting as a

WHY DOES ONE DEVELOP FASTER?
China's geography concentrates